

***BROKEN NEWS** WASN'T 'DARK', A GENRE BENDRE WANTED TO AVOID. HER CHARACTER HAD A 'STRONG VOICE', SHE WANTED TO HAVE 'HOPE'*

have "a strong voice" and not be "morally ambiguous". In the end, Bendre wanted there to be "hope".

Bendre says it was her battle with metastatic cancer in 2018-19 that led to this outlook: "It changed the way I looked at things," she says. "Recovering to a degree where I could work took time." Then Covid-19 struck. Bendre had begun reading scripts, but she wasn't enjoying what was coming her way. "It's not that I wanted the show to be all about me," she says. *Broken News* also features Jaideep Ahlawat, who heads a rival news channel, and Shriya Pilgaonkar as an intrepid reporter.

Getting back into the groove of being an actor took time. Lines—a lot of them—had to be learnt, and there was a whole new way of working she had to acclimatise herself with. "There were a lot of butterflies in the stomach; nervousness in a good way," says Bendre when recalling her first day on set. "Interestingly, Vinay made me do a difficult scene for my first shot. After we finished, I calmed down. By the end of day one, I was enjoying it."

So, did she watch primetime news coverage to prepare for the part? "I am still more of a reader of news than a watcher. I have been avoiding anything that gets my blood pressure up," she says with a smile. Qureshi, she adds, is not modelled on anyone. "She is an amalgamation of various people you see," says Bendre. "*Broken News* is not just about the media. We are not judging anybody. It holds a mirror to society. It tells you there is always time to make a U-turn and learn something."

Bendre's own learning shines through the books she recommends on her Instagram profile under the hashtag '#SBCBookOfTheMonth'. Her last book suggestion was the recently released *December in Dacca* by K.S. Nair. "True education is travelling and reading. If you can't afford to travel, then reading is the cheapest way to travel," she says. "It is great for understanding society and to get to know people." With social media, Bendre feels she can say things her way. "My real side has come out," she says. "It has changed the way I have been received and perceived."■

–Suhani Singh

musicians performing with western classical artists. After touring more than 35 international festivals, the independent drama releases on June 10 in select theatres.

Though she had no interest in directing a film, Haksar says it was old Delhi—a place she's familiar with—that made her want to put together a screenplay. "There is a multi-layered quality to old Delhi—multiplicity of cultures, communities and histories—that I felt only cinema can best capture," she says. "Yes, there's lot of difficulty, struggle and drudgery, but there's also so much love, life and laughter and dignity in each person." In *Ghode Ko...*, Haksar shows us the area through varying perspectives—a pickpocket (Ravindra Sahu), a guide conducting heritage walks (Lokesh Jain), a loader-activist (K. Gopalan) and a street food vendor (Raghubir Yadav).

FLIGHT IN OLD DELHI
Ghode ko Jalebi Khilane Le Ja Riya Hoon is releasing on June 10 in select theatres

Working with theatre actors and also amateurs, Haksar's stage approach seeps into her maiden feature. She jumps between genres—magic realism, documentary, real stories, dark comedy and dream narration—while interspersing Urdu poetry with facets of Delhi history. Though the canvas she paints is abstract and humane, it is one that can be demanding for viewers to follow.

What helps is that *Ghode Ko...* shows on screen a Delhi that is rarely seen. The capital's underbelly is beautifully shot by cinematographer Saumyananda Sahi whose earlier credits include the award-winning *Eeb Aaley Oo* (2019).

Subtlety is Haksar's biggest strength. In one scene, she showcases the "underlying tension that exists between two communities" in an area where diverse cultures are known to co-exist. In another, she highlights how exploitative tourism in marginalised areas can be as a Seva Kutir bus comes to clean up an area where beggars live.

Haksar held on to her passion project for over three years despite many asking her to take the OTT route for release. But like all true-blue theatre practitioners, she was stubborn. "I wanted to take the film to the very people—the migrant labourers, the pickpockets, the vendors—who are part of it," she says. "It is their film."■

–Suhani Singh